

Town of Westhampton
Town Hall
1 South Road
Westhampton, MA 01027

Finance Committee Meeting Minutes
Tuesday, November 11, 2014

The meeting convened at 7:00 PM

Present:

Finance Committee Members: Ellice Gonzalez, Jackie Brodeur, Mary Cleary, Aniko Giordano, Margaret Parsons, Joseph Pipczynski, Celeste Whiting.

1. Vote to accept minutes of FinCom meeting of 10/21/14. Vote 7-0-0.
2. Correspondence: The Association of Town Finance Committees notified us that there is a new handbook available. Cheryl will request copies of the CD for us.
The Beacon arrived. There is an article on a commission to review Chapter 70 school funding law.

3. Old Business:

Town Audit: Margie reports that there is nothing negative for us going forward. It was a clean audit. There remains a question about the tax collector balance.

Free Cash: Free Cash has been certified. It was a good number, but could have been better.

Celeste reported on her conversations with John Trickey, the Chair of the Pelham Finance Committee. According to Mr. Trickey, Pelham was in such dire straits financially that they were considering trying to merge with Amherst. He explained their process for remaining autonomous and rural/residential and how they eventually were able to fully fund their capital plan and the town for the next 5-10 years. Through previous years, budget analysis and departmental outreach and education, the town was able to pass a 2 million dollar override (\$200,000 each year for 10 years) and become financially secure. We decided we will have an informal study group to look into how we can help our town in such a way.

FY15 Budget Process Review: We reviewed the work that Aniko, Mary and Tom did for the budget template and the sample budget. Minor adjustments were made. Mary will send the template to Margie for final formatting and sending to Cheryl.

Budget Process Letter: We reviewed the letter Ellice composed for distribution to departments along with the new budget template. Minor adjustments were made.

Accounts Payable Clerk Search: This process is on hold as we are now posting for the Accounting position.

4. New Business:

HRSD budget: Ellice and Margie attended the HRSD school committee meeting on Tuesday, November 4. Ellice reports that the primary goal of the meeting was to look at the state money for regional transportation as the Regional received more than anticipated from the state. The regional received approximately \$140,000 in additional transportation funds. The regional had budgeted an amount that fell short of actual costs by approximately \$89,000, so the additional funds will cover that shortfall. The school would like to put the additional funds into a revolving fund for transportation. Needs a 2/3 vote from the HRSD school committee.

Ellice also reported that the HRSD will have a meeting on Mon. Dec. 8 to discuss the FY16 budget. In January they will hold a public presentation and will vote on the budget in February. There is not capital plan for the school district.

Worthington: There are plans to have Worthington open a public elementary school, have Worthington students attend HRHS and begin transitioning Worthington into the HRSD. There are some concerns over the process by which this is happening.

IT Audit: We reviewed the proposal sent by Paragus. We noted that the proposal is far more than we need at the moment and too expensive. The Selectboard will request proposals from three companies for bids on some of the more crucial items. FinCom expressed concern about the lack of password protection of Town of Westhampton information and work stations.

Special Town Meeting: We voted to add articles regarding counsel fees and veteran's benefits to the Special Town Meeting warrant. Voted 7-0-0.

Tax Rate: Margie reviewed a tax rate worksheet with us. We discussed the levy limit and the FY15 budget.

Next meeting will take place on Tuesday, December 2 at 7:00, which is Celeste's birthday. Happy Birthday, Celeste!

Respectfully submitted by Mary Cleary